NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

7TH PARLIAMENT

PARLIAMENTARY STANDING COMMITTEE ON NATURAL RESOURCES

REPORT ON THE VISITS TO CONSERVANCIES IN KUNENE AND ZAMBEZI REGIONS

March 2025

Report No. 5 of 2025

ACRONYMS

BDP -	BENEFITS DISTRIBUTION PLAN
CBNRM –	COMMUNITY BASED NATURAL RESOURCES MANAGEMENT
CITES –	CONVENTION ON INTERNATIONAL TRADE IN ENDANGERED SPECIES OF WILD FAUNA AND FLORA
ECC -	ENVIRONMENTAL CLEARANCE CERTIFICATES
EIF –	ENVIRONMENTAL INVESTMENT FUND
EPL -	EXPLORATION MINING LICENCES
GOSCARs -	GRASSROOTS OWEN-SMITH COMMUNITY RANGER AWARDS
HWC –	HUMAN/WILDLIFE CONCLICT
IRDNC -	INTEGRATED RURAL DEVELOPMENT AND NATURE CONSERVATION
KAZA-TFCA –	KAVANGO ZAMBEZI TRANSFRONTIER CONSERVATION AREA
METF-	MINISTRY OF ENVIRONMENT, TOURISM AND FORESTRY
MPs –	MEMBERS OF PARLIAMENT
NACSO -	NAMIBIAN ASSOCIATION OF CBNRM SUPPORT ORGANISATIONS
NGOs –	NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANISATIONS
NNNF -	NAMIBIA NATURE FOUNDATION
SRT -	SAVE THE RHINO TRUST NAMIBIA
TA –	TRADITIONAL AUTHORITY
UNESCO -	UNITED NATIONS EDUCATIONAL, SCIENTIFIC AND CULTURAL ORGANIZATION
WWF –	WORLD WILDLIFE FUND

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Namibia's communal conservancies and community forests are self-governing entities legally recognized by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Tourism (MEFT). To-date, there are about 86 registered conservancies in Namibia. Each conservancy has an elected management committee that is spearheading its operations. Conservancies are there to conserve and protect the environment and to earn revenue from the sustainable use of the natural resources.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee deemed it necessary to visit conservancies in Kunene and Zambezi regions, to familiarize themselves with the operation of communal conservancies and assess their progress including challenges they are facing. The committee further wanted to understand whether conservancies are complying with matters related to environmental management and sustainability, and whether there is any gap in execution of relevant regulations.

The restrictions in quota allocations imposed by the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of wild fauna and flora (CITES), poor financial management, the interference of the traditional authorities in the affairs of conservancies and; outdated national policy on Wildlife Management form part of the major findings.

The importance of wildlife cannot be overemphasized due to the benefit it brings to the nation at large, however certain measures should be in place to ensure the community at large are benefiting from the conservancies in their respective areas. Thus, it is important to review the National Policy on Wildlife Management to narrow the gap in execution of conservancies mandates and ensure smooth collaboration with the Traditional Authorities.

1 Introduction

The enactment of the Communal Conservancy legislation in 1996 culminated in the Community Based Natural Resources Management (CBNRM) programme that paved the way for community members to directly benefit from the conservation of natural resources through the creation of conservancies in their areas. CBNRM gives exclusive rights for sustainable use and management of natural resources in rural communities. The programme has empowered rural communities to conserve and manage their own natural resources in order to improve their livelihood.

To-date, there are about 86 registered conservancies in Namibia, with 15 of them in the Zambezi region, including 3 game parks and one association under the CBNRM programme, while 38 conservancies are found in Kunene region

Namibia's communal conservancies and community forests are self-governing entities legally recognized by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Tourism (MEFT). Each conservancy has an elected management committee that is spearheading its operations. Conservancies are there to conserve and protect the environment and to earn revenue from the sustainable use of the natural resources.

During the period of January / February 2023, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Natural Resources visited nine (9) conservancies in Kunene region to familiarize itself with the operation of communal conservancies and assess their progress. The committee further found it prudent to extend the oversight visits to the Zambezi region, in order to compare its findings, and holistically find solutions to the challenges facing conservancies. Thus, the visit to conservancies in Zambezi region was undertaken from the 05 – 09 June 2023.

Initially, the committee intended to visit twelve (12) conservancies in Zambezi region. However, the committee learned that Kabulabula and Kasika conservancies were not accessible due to floods at the time of the visit while, Zoti conservancy which also formed part of the program, could not be visited because it was closed when the committee was in the region. Thus, a total number of nine (9) conservancies were visited in the region.

2 Objectives of the visit were to:

2.1 Acquaint Members of Parliament with knowledge and understanding of environmental management and sustainability;

2.2 Engage community members involved in CBNRM, tourism and forestry management in Zambezi region and discuss the hindering factors in the implementation of the programme;

2.3 Enable members to consider matters concerning environmental management and sustainability;

2.4 Identify gaps in the execution of the CBNRM and other relevant regulations,

2.5 Report on its findings to the Committee for possible adoption and subsequent tabling in the National Assembly.

3 Methodology

In order to fulfil its mandate, the committee visited and held meetings with the Regional Governors, relevant stakeholders and conservancies at their respective offices.

4 Composition of the delegation

The group was comprised of four Members of Parliament (MPs) and two staff;

Hon. Agnes Mpingana Kafula - Head of the delegation

Hon. Mike Venaani

Hon. Tangeni Iijambo

Hon. Annaklethe Sikerete

Ms. Anaalisa Meroro – Chief Parliamentary Clerk

Mr George Sanzila – Chief Information Officer

Ms Frankhilde Endjala – Chief Parliamentary Clerk.

5 Purpose of the report

The purpose of this report is to inform the National Assembly of the committee's findings on the visit to the conservancies in Kunene and Zambezi regions for further actions.

6 Meeting with the relevant stakeholders

At a meeting with the Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism and other stakeholders such as Integrated Rural Development and Nature Conservation (IRDNC), Namibia Nature Foundation (NNF), and Save the Rhino Trust Namibia (SRT) in Kunene region, it was revealed that the Community Based Natural Resources Management (CBNRM) program continues to empower rural communities with over 230 community members having been involved in the conservation of their natural resources, resulting in the creation of 5 000 full time and part-time jobs and generating over 130 million Dollars in revenue since the program's inception.

The Director of Wildlife and Parks in the Ministry of Environment and Tourism, Bennett Kahuure, narrated that the enactment of the communal conservancy legislation in 1996 culminated in CBNRM program, which has paved the way for community members to directly benefit from the management and conservation of natural resources through the creation of conservancies. Additionally, supporting policies such as the National Policy on Management of Natural Resources, the Concessions policy on tourism, and the 1998 revised Policy on Human and Wildlife conflict management have also been set up. CBNRM gives exclusive rights to using and managing valuable natural resources to rural communities to benefit sustainably.

Kahuure further stated that the protracted Wildlife and Protected Areas Management Bill, expected to replace the outdated Nature Conservation Ordinance of 1975, will soon be enacted. The legislation addresses many shortcomings in managing natural resources and will likely pass early 2023.

According to Kahuure, there are 38 registered conservancies found in the Kunene region. That starkly contrasts with only four conservancies in 1998, at the initiative's inception.

Despite the growing benefits associated with this sector, Kahuure bemoaned poaching, particularly the illegal trafficking of Rhino horns, as a significant challenge, resulting in the numbers of this highly endangered species decreasing tremendously. According to MEFT, these species are only in four African countries: South Africa, Namibia, Zimbabwe, and Kenya.

In 2021 alone, there were 40 cases of poaching, which increased to 87 in 2022, especially in the Etosha National Park. In order to enhance the protection of these species and involve community members in conservation, the Ministry has started giving rights and custodianship over key species to commercial farmers to curb poaching, as 50% of the income generated by communities under the CBNRM comes from trophy hunting. We further uncovered isolated

cases of misappropriation of monies generated by conservancies by members calling for our concerted efforts to address this challenge.

Climate change has increased Human Wildlife Conflict (HWC) cases and has come under the spotlight. Kunene region is a semi-arid area. Although it received a few showers sometimes, it experienced long spells of drought over the years, leading to wildlife migrating or destroying people's homes and infrastructure and attacking and killing domesticated animals.

As a result, community members have been appealing to MEFT to increase the quota for trophy hunting, especially problematic animals such as lions, which they say would help curtail the increased losses the community is suffering. However, MEFT explained that an animal census that was conducted by MEFT before the Committee's visit put the number of lions in the area at only 56, with fewer adults. As part of efforts to find solutions to human-wildlife conflict, MEFT appealed to lawmakers to advocate for an increased budget. They further urged international conservation pressure groups to equally get involved in losses suffered by community members due to HWC just as they advocate for their preservation. Previously MEFT paid N$5000 as offset for loss of life resulting from human-wildlife conflict, which has increased to N$100 000. Large livestock such as cattle amounts to N$3000, that is below the market value.

According to the Ministry, more than N$40 million in compensation has been paid since the fund's inception. They have further suggested that members of conservancies should explore conservation funding opportunities in more prosperous countries. The Ministry believes that other revenue-generating initiatives, such as renewable energy sources, wind and solar power energy, and abundant green hydrogen in rural areas, could help communities generate additional income for their livelihood.

At the same meeting, the Namibian Association of Support Organisations (NASCO) echoed similar sentiments adding that the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic and the classification of Namibia as an upper middle-income country has worsened financial resources. The latter has resulted in funding challenges for civil society organizations. NASCO is the umbrella organization that links communities and organizations that manage and conserve Namibia's natural resources in communal areas and assists conservancies in setting up governance structures and strategies to generate income.

7 Meeting with Traditional Leaders, Community representatives and conservancies in Kunene region

7.1 //Huab and Uibasen (Twyfelfontein) conservancies

Community members and representatives of traditional authorities in Khorixas complained about increased cases of HWC as the community continues to lose crops and livestock due to wild animals such as elephants and lions that also damaging infrastructure. The community implored lawmakers to help in finding a solution to this challenge. Water scarcity and poor road infrastructure remain significant challenges in the area. Even though the Khorixas constituency is rich in mineral resources, the community complained about local people were not participating in mining activities, while those involved in small-scale mining do not have access to the market and must rely on visiting tourists to sell their products. They further bemoaned the regulation related to charcoal production, adding that it was prohibitive and a hindrance for those that wanted to earn a living.

According to conservancy members, the Ministry of Mines and Energy continues to grant Environmental Clearance Certificates (ECC) for mining activities in restricted animal core areas, which has resulted in the migration of wildlife, especially Rhinos, to other areas due to noise. The situation has further affected the collection of revenue for the cash-strapped conservancies, affecting the livelihood of the community.

Conservancy Committee members added that besides mining activities disrupting tourism and conservation efforts, locals are also excluded, with no money plowed back into the community through social responsibility programs.

It also came to light that the //Huab conservancy, which only relied upon trophy hunting as a source of income, faces the prospect of closure after its joint venture agreement with a tour operator, Ultimate Safaris, that ended recently. The Conservancy would only have one option besides retrenching the Rhino rangers and other staff if no solution was found by February 2023. Conservancy members noted that repeated attempts to seek a meeting with the Minister of Environment, Forestry, and Tourism to find a solution have proved futile. At Twyfelfontein, conservancy members echoed similar sentiments, lamenting their exclusion in the management of the famous rock engravings heritage site located in the area, which is said to be under the auspices of the National Heritage Council of Namibia. UNESCO has inscribed the heritage site as a cultural site for its large concentration of rock carvings. Even though revenue was collected on behalf of the state from tourists who visit the area by the council, the Conservancy

bemoaned that it had no share in the benefits. Other challenges identified included HWC, lack of electricity, and poor road infrastructure.

7.2 Torra and #Khaodi //Hoas conservancies

Members of the Torra conservancy decried the compensation policy for losses incurred due to human/wildlife conflict, calling for an urgent review of the law. According to the Conservancy, the policy formulation needed more comprehensive initial consultations, and the community had to bear the brunt of losing their livestock and critical infrastructure, such as water points. As a result, the Conservancy faces the mammoth task of convincing community members of the importance of co-existing with wildlife while they paradoxically continue to incur losses. According to community members, MEFT compensate farmers by losing their livestock between N$1000 and N$3000, a far cry from the market value estimated at N$10 000. In addition, they complained that compensation for damage to crops was limited to farmers who cultivate fields exceeding a hectare, making it difficult for community members who rely on small-scale garden projects for their livelihood.

Members of the Conservancy further feel that even though they continue to manage and conserve wildlife, benefits from such activities are negligible compared to private investors and wildlife researchers profiting enormously at their expense. Conservancy members stated that they have since decided to take human-wildlife conflict mitigating measures, such as the erection of kraals and wildlife detecting devices, but such efforts have proven to be futile.

At #Khoadi //Hoas conservancy, one of the success stories in community-based conservation, with over 2000 registered members, took initiative to supplement the little amount the Ministry offers as offset. As a result of the protracted drought, however, this initiative faces the prospect of failure, as many wild animals perish, with the remaining animals migrating to areas with greener pastures, resulting in increased incidences of human/wildlife conflict due to the prey-to-predator ratio that has drastically reduced. Despite this significant challenge, the Conservancy continues to create employment for locals, including sponsoring educational sponsorships to students from poor backgrounds.

7.3 Anabeb and Sesfontein conservancies

During a courtesy call on the Constituency Councillor for Sesfontein, Hon. Hendrik Gaobaeb, that preceded the community meeting, he bemoaned monetary benefits gained by

conservancies from joint ventures formed with management companies, adding that the Ministry should monitor the wildlife researchers as they often deviate from their authorized activities to engage in the illegal tourism business.

He stated that even though conservancies are applying for leasehold, they often need more from joint ventures, but they sometimes get as low as 8%. In addition, the Councillor accused private investors who own lodges of exploiting employees by paying them poor salaries with little to no benefits. He further cautioned conservancies to be accountable to the community, noting that every asset acquired by the Conservancy, including using money, should be accounted for accordingly.

Hon. Gaobaeb narrated that particular emphasis should be on monitoring mining areas, which he said have proven to be hotspots for poachers, particularly Rhino poaching. He said HWC is a significant challenge, requiring concerted efforts from all stakeholders, noting that communities should also desist from tendencies of moving to areas inhabited mainly by wildlife.

The continued trend of settling in core areas designated for wildlife in the two conservancies of Anabeb and Sesfontein is a significant challenge that has increased incidences of HWC and contributed to animals' migration. According to the two conservancies, they hold little power to remove people settling in the conservancy core areas as they have to rely on the help of the traditional authorities that have jurisdiction over the land. They further explained that the rising number of predators against the declining numbers of prey has increased HWC. Even though plans are afoot to help supplement the government with its compensation efforts, they implored the government to look into its compensation policy urgently.

Moreover, they decried slow response from MEFT to emergencies concerning losses due to wildlife. They suggested that predators such as lions could be translocated to other areas to solve the human-wildlife conflict.

The two conservancies have assisted students with their school registration fees, erected and rehabilitated boreholes, provided food and funeral assistance, and continued to help traditional authorities financially. Due to transport challenges faced by the area, the two conservancies and the Tora conservancy acquired an ambulance to ease transport challenges faced by patients on referral to the district hospital. Challenges identified included alleged misuse of financial resources and assets and lack of tangible benefits to community members.

Traditional leaders, however, praised CBNRM for improving the lives of the rural poor, further welcoming the Wildlife and Protected Areas Management Bill envisaged to replace the outdated Nature Conservation Ordinance of 1975. The mentioned Bill, that would be passed into law, is envisaged to address a wide range of shortcomings in managing natural resources.

7.4 Otuzemba and Ehirovipuka

During a meeting with community and conservancy committee members of Otuzemba conservancy, which has over 251 registered members, concerns were raised regarding the lack of hunting quota for the Conservancy by MEFT. The Conservancy stated that the increase in the quota allocation would have helped the Conservancy raise revenue urgently needed after prolonged spells of drought that have resulted in increased cases of HWC. Members recommended the construction of many solar-powered boreholes for wildlife to reduce instances of HWC.

Farmers living within the boundaries of the Conservancy who have suffered losses due to wildlife have not been compensated for more than six years due to a lack of money and proper coordination between the Conservancy and MEFT. It also came to light that infightings between conservancy members have affected operations with no accountability for finances spent by the Conservancy.

The Ehirovipuka conservancy has over 700 registered members, with much of its income derived from trophy hunting. However, the members repeated the sentiments that the money generated was insufficient for development in the area due to drought and lack of quota. The Conservancy has assisted farmers with fodder and other necessities despite limited resources. The Conservancy further assists students with payments of their tuition. HWC is prevalent in the area, with the broken Etosha National Park fence adjacent to the site aggravating matters as predators from the park freely roam the area and attack both humans and wildlife. Community members stated they were not allowed near the fence for security reasons.

The conservancy members were also unhappy with the amount offered as compensation for losses set at N$60 000 per Conservancy, suggesting that compensation per livestock must be N$15 000 and loss of human life at N$1 million. They further implored MEFT to repair the fence and move the fence 5 kilometres inwards to reduce losses. Illegal settlement in animal core areas is another concern, including poaching.

As part of mitigation measures, the Conservancy has intensified patrols and built lion-proof kraals and early warning systems such as monitoring devices fitted on animals.

The Conservancy invited interested investors to run tourism activities in the area. It also came to light that the two conservancies; Ehirovipuka and Otuzemba have created an initiative called People's Park, another nature reserve intended to boost employment and income generation for the two communities. However, the people's park has irked a faction of the community that feels it has reduced their land as they reside between the Etosha National Park and the purported reserve. The community further raised concerns regarding the issuance of EPLs without the consent of traditional leaders, adding that locals in the area should enjoy priority when they apply for EPL licenses.

A representative of Otuzemba conservancy suggested that MEFT should be allocate yearly quotas on problem animals such as lions that continue to kill domestic animals in the area. With increasing HWC cases, Otuzemba conservancy also complained of a lack of weapons for Rangers, who are at risk of getting attacked when confronted by wild animals. The Conservancy has also assisted farmers with seeds and student tuition and has sponsored sporting activities. According to the Conservancy, the people's park initiative would not encroach on people's property as no fence would be erected in the area by the Conservancies. The majority of community members consulted were in support of the intended people's park.

8 Meetings with the Regional Governor and conservancies in Zambezi region

8.1 Zambezi regional Governor

Zambezi Regional Governor, Hon. Lawrence Sampofu indicated that human wildlife conflict has drastically increased due to the region finding itself in the middle of the Kavango, Zambezi Trans-Frontier Conservation Area (KAZA-TFCA), the second largest nature and landscape conservation area in the world covering a landmass of over 519,912 km2. He stated that the region is experiencing a high number of crocodiles, hippos and lions attacking both people including the destruction of crops by elephants that number over 6,000 and other animals who at the same time compete for water with humans. He further noted that the compensation given to farmers is too little and that there was a need for the MEFT to urgently address this challenge.

Hon. Sampofu stated that despite some conservancies found in the region generating significant incomes, many continue to grapple with poor financial management and governance.

According to him this has in turn affected operations leading some to fail while those that are managing their finances well have gone a step further by funding major projects.

8.2 Lusese Conservancy

Lusese conservancy was established in 2014 with a total number of 4002 registered members. The conservancy solely relies on hunting and safari camp for revenue. Out of revenue generated, the conservancy has managed to build an office and a resource centre. The Environmental Investment Fund (EIF) have also come to the rescue of the conservancy by donating a boat to help transport school learners and community members during the times of floods. However, the revenue for the conservancy has been drastically reduced following a decision by MEFT to reduce their hunting quota allocations.

Several letters requesting a review of the quota allocations have been written to MEFT but such requests have not been heeded. Hunting quota for elephants and Hippos have been reduced from five to only two, and for Zebras and crocodiles the number has been reduced from 15 to 10. Even though there appears to be a large population of buffaloes and kudus in the area, no quota allocations were given for both species. This has adversely affected their operations as they rely on hunting quotas to generate revenue. Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- Water scarcity – there are no boreholes in the conservancy and when it is dry, animals relocate to other conservancies or parks due to drought. Although the conservancy drilled its own borehole and rehabilitated an old one, they are not enough to cater for all animals. The third borehole couldn't be completed due to lack of funds.
- Financial constraints – there is no enough funds to build water dams for animals. As a result, animals are often poached when they travel far in search of water.
- Illegal fishing – There are few fishing guards as there is no money to pay them. Foreign nationals from Zambia are crossing the borders for illegal fishing and hunting. They also use illegal fishing methods to catch fish including fingerlings
- The reduction of hunting quotas allocation which is the main source of income is a major challenge. Quota allocations for species such as elephants and crocodiles are predetermined by the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species (CITES) and Namibia as a member of this body has to comply.

8.3 Salambala conservancy

Salambala conservancy is found in the area called Sibulamunda which is hardly flooded and has a big forest under the Masubia Traditional Authority (TA). Its constitution was drafted with its borders defined by the TA. Salambala was registered in June 1998. It has a size of 908 square kilometres which is divided into parts of wildlife, farming and tourisms (lodges and campsites).

The conservancy has the advantage of an ever increasing number of different wildlife species (especially elephants and impala) as it borders the Chobe National Park in Botswana. Members of the conservancy received training in various management skills that have contributed to the success of their operations. Its source of income include a lodge owned by the conservancy in partnership with an investor, a guesthouse and hunting quota allocations. In the year 2022, the conservancy through its social responsibility, funded a student at the University of Namibia. Additionally, schools in the community receive donations from the conservancy on a yearly basis.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- Absence of a management committee since February 2023 due to internal squabbles
- The vastness of the area makes it difficult to patrol and guard;
- Water scarcity is contributing to wild animals migrating to other conservancies in search of water;
- Poor financial management from the previous committee has affected the operation of the conservancy;
- Non-implementation of some of the major activities such as the signing of a hunting contract and the payment of the salaries of game guards and other employees at the conservancy as a result of the non-appointment of new management committee. The situation has been aggravated by previous signatories to the conservancy bank account who have been uncooperative and refuse to hand over power to a new committee due to a protracted dispute.
- Reduction in quota allocation due to restrictions imposed by the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of wild fauna and flora (CITES).

8.4 Balyerwa Conservancy

Balyerwa conservancy was registered in 2006, with a size of 223 square kilometers. The conservancy has been making progress in empowering community members living in the areas of Nongozi, Mbambazi, Sauzuo, Nambali and Lyanshulu which fall under the conservancy.

Knox Salushando, the Chairperson of the conservancy, indicated that the conservancy employs over 24 staff members drawn from the local community. In 2022, the conservancy generated revenue of over N$3 million and has been making conceited efforts to improve the livelihood of people in the area, despite experiencing a reduction in the allocation of its hunting quotas. He stated that the conservancy contributed money amounting to over 300 000 for the construction of the chief's palace and has sponsored students with total amount of 30 000 and have gone further by supporting the five sub Khutas and local churches. Salushando noted that the conservancy has further embarked on projects such as assisting community members with easy access to the water pipelines and electrifying villages. A budget of over 1.5 million for the electrification project has already been set aside initially targeting 3 areas of Sauzuo, Nambali and Lyanshulu. He further revealed that as part of efforts to derive maximum benefits from the management of natural resources, the conservancy has successfully managed to negotiate for a 15% increase in the price of hunting quotas, with the identified professional hunter having further agreed to sponsor a total amount of N$750 000 towards the development of the area and assisting in the setting up of a camp site, craft centre, traditional village, community hostel and a clinic.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- Despite the successes, the interference of the traditional authorities in the affairs of conservancies in the region was identified as a major challenge that continue to threaten progress. Some families who reside in the area but pay their allegiances to different traditional authorities, are being side-lined by the traditional authority, **(see annexure A)** even though, the constitution clearly stipulates that a community member may only stop to become a member when they die, resign or migrate to other areas and not tribal affiliation.
- There is a plan to set up a 2000 hectares' green scheme in the Lyanshulu area close to the Mudumu National Park. The de-bushing exercise in this area is likely to scare away the wildlife as the conservancy is bordered by both Mudumu and Nkasa Rupara National Parks that are feeding the conservancy with animals.

- Over fishing is another major concern that has adversely affected the operations of the conservancy. Fish reserves in the area have become a hotbed for illegal fishing by foreign nationals mainly from Zambia and Angola, who are also said to be employing illegal fishing methods. These foreigners are setting up camps for more than six months. They bribe local people who apply for fishing permits on their behalf and use prohibited monofilament nets to catch fish. Although the matter has been reported to the authorities they are often, told that there is no transport.
- Human Wildlife Conflict (HWC) is another major challenge. The conservancy is currently processing over 50 claims for year 2022 alone to compensate affected families.
- Poaching is also a concern in the conservancy.

8.5 Bamunu conservancy

Bamunu conservancy was inaugurated by the Chief of the Mafwe Traditional Authority in 2003 with the attendance of five headmen representatives of (Malundu, Kanono, Shaile, Chncimane and Muketela). The conservancy project was initiated by His Majesty, Litunga George Simasiku Mamili at the special meeting held on 14 August 2003 in Chichimane village. It was during the said meeting that Litunga appointed and charged two persons; Francis Mazezo Imenda and John Musa Mwilima to start a conservation project within the Muketela district with additional members nominated by the headmen which constituted a committee.

On the 23rd March 2004, it adopted the Constitution and was completed and signed on the 28th August 2006. In March 2011, Bamunu was gazetted with a membership of 450 people, which increased to over 1000 by the time of the visit with 16 permanent employees on a full time basis and16 committee members benefiting allowances on a monthly basis.

In the 2012 budget, five communities under Bamunu conservancy benefited N$10 000.00 each as per the Benefits Distribution Plan (BDP). During the period of 2013 – 2015, it generated an amount of N$661 000.00 as development fund for rural electrification. Additionally, the conservancy is assisting community members with the provision of farming implements, including a tractor that is currently being used to plough for farmers in the community at a reasonable fee as per the agreement between the conservancy management and the community. Plans are underway to buy more farming implements for the purposes of starting a green scheme project.

The conservancy further stated that HWC is becoming frequent and wide spread in the area, and that it has become difficult to convince community members about the importance of conservation when their fields are being destroyed by wild animals with little compensation. They appealed for a review of the compensation policy. Community members who reside in animals' core areas of the conservancy have also become a hindrance to conservation efforts, further contributing to HWC.

8.6 Mashi Conservancy

The Mashi conservancy was established with the support of Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) with the aim of improving the livelihood of community members in the area. It started its operations in 1998 but only registered on the 01st March 2003. The conservancy is one of the oldest (5th conservancy in the region and 16th in the country) conservancies in the Zambezi region with a size of 297 square kilometres. It is bordering the Mudumu National Park on the southern part and Mayuni conservancy in the north, with 3000 registered members governed by 17 management committee members. Mashi conservancy has 3 recognized wildlife corridors; Sharungura, Ngonga and Masikisiki.

Mostly, it generates its income through trophy hunting and tourism joint venture agreements. There are four communities making up the conservancy namely; Sachona, Lubuta, Namushasha and Lizauli who benefit over 50% from revenue generated from its activities. Over 100 villages have benefited from rural electrification and water provision initiatives with the conservancy having spent over N$2 million to that effect. The conservancy has also built Lubuta Primary School classroom block, Sachona and Ngonga community hostels, and has provided assistance to students from impoverished families who intend to further their studies and, provides funeral covers for conservancy members.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- Wildlife corridors are cleared for farming purpose scaring off wildlife
- The reduction in quotas allocation has adversely affected income generation
- Tourism Joint venture agreement income has decreased due to COVID-19
- New sub-khutas on the increase have resulted in conflict with conservancy
- HWC – loss of cattle, damage of crops and human loss.
- Little benefit to the conservancy members due to COVID-19 pandemic which brought / contributed to low income

8.7 Kwandu Conservancy

Kwandu conservancy was registered on 02 December 1999. The conservancy is solely dependent on trophy hunting for its income. To supplement its income streams, in May 2009, the conservancy started with harvesting devils' claw. It consists of 190 km while the forest consists of 212 km with an approximate population of 5450. Kongola, Sesheke, Sikunga, Mwazi and Singalamwe are the five areas found within Kwandu. Although the conservancy has been in existence for more than 20 years, nothing much has been happening.

The management committee indicated that, since the announcement of a moratorium on timber harvesting, the conservancy has been struggling to generate income. Before the moratorium, the conservancy had managed to buy 5 electrical transformers for the community. By the time the committee visited the conservancy, employees had not been paid their monthly salaries of May 2023.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- lack of water since the windmill was destroyed by elephants,
- Lack of transport and land disputes within the conservancy which discourage investors to engage in conservancy activities.

8.8 Sobbe conservancy

Sobbe conservancy started operating in 2004 before it was registered in October 2006. The conservancy consists of six villages with 1098 registered members and 15 management committee members. It is neighbouring Nzoti, Mashi and the Mudumu national Park. The conservancy is well known for properly managing, monitoring and sustaining a state forest (animals' corridor) found in the area and has received an award amounting to N$40 000-00 as a token of appreciation from the Wild World Fund (WWF) as well as N$ 100 000-00 from Grassroots Owen-Smith Community Ranger Awards (GOSCARs) Foundation which they won in 2022 for the same reason. The main source of income for this conservancy is trophy hunting.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- Members of the conservancy aired concerns regarding some community members who settle in animal core areas, aggravating the human wildlife conflict crisis that is rife in most conservancies.
- Poaching, illegal fishing and harvesting of other natural resources.

8.9 Sikunga conservancies

Sikunga conservancy was established in 2004 and inaugurated on 21 August 2011 by Hon. Netumbo Nandi Ndeitwah. The conservancy covers 310 square kilometres and employs 41 people, with 11 management committee members. It generates its main income from trophy hunting, Muvala lodge and the sale of other natural resources. Members of this conservancy complained about the tendency of allocating quotas to the same professional hunters. This is one of the main reasons that delays completion of quotas allocated annually to the professional hunters. Although the reduction of quota allocations has affected all conservancies, Sikunga seems to be performing well compared to some conservancies in the region.

The conservancy has managed to sponsor five (5) students in 2022 to the amount of N$ 60 000-00 and nine (9) students in 2023, to further their studies at tertiary institutions which covered 75% of tuition fees being paid per student that brings the total amount for the year to N$ 111 926-00. A small dining hall was also built for a school found in the area to the amount N$ 50 000-00. They also bought a transformer for rural electrification in their community and drilled two (2) boreholes for wild animals. Other achievements include, cash benefits to orphans and vulnerable school children and, constructed two rooms for Nasisangani Kindergarten to the amount of N$ 32 500-00.

The conservancy depends on wild animals migrating from Botswana. In 2011 the conservancy received some translocated animal species such as giraffes, wild beast, impala, kudus, waterbucks and ilanda. Some of these animals have since migrated elsewhere.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancy include;

- The conservancy faces similar challenges such as poaching, illegal fishing, illegal harvesting of poles and reeds, fish guards' attacks, and
- People settling in the animal core areas.

8.10 Mayuni Conservancy

Mayuni conservancy is the 8th conservancy in Namibia and 3rd in the region that was officially registered in December 1999. It covers a size of 151 square kilometres with- a population of 2600 registered members. There are 3 areas under this conservancy; Choi, Kayuwo and Kapako with 70 villages headed by one TA and 2 sub-khutas. The source of income includes lodges and campsites although, two lodges were burnt by fire; namely Susuwe lodge in 2014 Mazambalala lodge in 2016 respectively.

Some of the challenges facing the conservancies include;

- Some species like ilanda, antelopes and kudus are not compensated for damaging crops based on the policy.
- Request for permit to manage problematic animals is not decentralized as one has to apply to the Regional office and the process is long and cumbersome.
- Crocodile farm project in the Mayuni conservancy has become a white elephant despite huge amounts of money spent and the project taking up a vast area of the conservancy. The conservancy is allocated a plot in Bwabwata National Park, where they invested N$ 5 000 000-00 as a start-up capital. Unfortunately, the owner of the Lodge who they have signed an agreement with passed on in October 2022. Currently, there is no business taking place.

9 Main findings

9.1 Restrictions in quota allocations imposed by the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of wild fauna and flora (CITES), have contributed to the reduction in the number of hunting quotas allocated to conservancies for some species, despite their population increasing and, in the process, leading to cases of human wildlife conflict.

9.2 Namibia is a signatory to the CITES convention, an international agreement between governments aimed at ensuring that international trade in wild animals and plants does not threaten the survival of the species. Even though hunting quotas are determined following the annual game count exercise, some of the species are allocated to conservancies based on conditions set out by CITES.

9.3 Compensation policy for losses incurred as a result of human-wildlife conflict is not justifiable. Communities complain that the Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism compensates farmers between N$1 000 and N$3 000 for livestock lost to predators, yet the market value for the livestock is around N$10 000.

9.4 Lack of financial management training for conservancy management committee members affecting operations.

9.5 Interference of the traditional authorities in the affairs of conservancies in the region continue to threaten progress.

9.6 Community members settling in animals' core areas contribute to HWC and land disputes between communities.

9.7 An increase in the number of sub-khuta affect finances of conservancies as they have to benefit from the conservancies annually.

9.8 Some professional hunters are allocated more than one quota from conservancies, making it difficult to effect hunting production timely due to overload.

9.9 Kongola Crocodile farm in the Mayuni conservancy which was initiated by the Ministry of Trade and Industrialization in year 2011 is on a stand still since year 2016. Additionally, the project sits on a vast area making up the conservancy.

9.10 Mayuni Conservancy was allocated a plot in Bwabwata Park where they invested N$ 5 000 000-00 as a start-up capital but unfortunately the owner passed on in October 2022. Currently, there is no business taking place.

9.11 MEFT should consider assisting conservancies with fenced and electrified water boreholes in conservancies where there is no enough water for animals.

10 Conclusion

The importance of the conservancies need to be prioritised to ensure conservation and sustainable management of the natural resources in improving the livelihood of the Namibian nation. Hence it is crucial for METF to pray its role and address the need of the conservancies at large. Equally, the absence of financial management, necessary skills and tribal issues which are hindrance of the conservancies' operation need much attention. Thus, the operation and success of the conservancies depend on the METF's willingness to assist and support to ensure they meet their objectives.

11 Recommendations

11.1 MEFT should offer basic accounting and bookkeeping training to conservancy treasurers and other financial officers to be able to handle their finances effectively and efficient.

11.2 MEFT to spearhead and facilitate peer learning among the conservancies in collaboration with civil society organisations to allow exchange of experiences to improve their operations, to also include benchmark visits to other countries.

11.3 MEFT to Review the compensation policy with a view to increase the amount payable to victims of HAWC.

11.4 MEFT in collaboration with Traditional leaders to address the issue of people resettling in animal corridors or ploughing beyond allocated borders.

11.5 MEFT in collaboration with TA to consider gazetting animal corridors

11.6 Conservancies to ensure that Community Guards are equipped with night vision binoculars, guns and boats to effectively carry out their duties.

11.7 MEFT to ensure that all animals that can cause HWC should be included in the policy.

11.8 MEFT to decentralise authorization of permit system at regional level.

Signatories

Hon. Tjekero Tweya (Chairperson) .....

Hon. Agnes Mpingana Kafula (Deputy Chairperson) .....

Hon. Herlinde Tjiveze .....

Hon. Vincent Joseph Mareka .....

Hon. Maria Elago .....

Hon. Diederik Vries .....

Hon. Gotthard Kasuto .....

Hon. Natangue Ithete .....

Hon. Kletus Karondo .....

Hon. Paula Kooper .....

Hon. Sebastiaan Karupu .....

Hon. Hilaria Mukapuli .....

Hon. Jan Mukwiilongo .....

Hon. Maria Kamutali .....

Hon. Nghidipohamba Hamata .....

Hon. Johanna Kandjimi .....

Hon. Fenni Nanyeni .....

Hon. Annakletha Sikerete .....

Hon. Mike Venaani .....

Hon. Ephraim Nekongo .....

Hon Utaara Mooutu .....

Hon Inna Hengari .....

Hon. Rebbeca Kambayi .....

Hon. Dr. Daniel Kashikola .....

Hon Apius Auchab .....

Hon. Kennedy Shekupakela .....